

The Cook County Justice Advisory Council

The Illinois Offense Code Table (OCT) lists the state’s criminal charge codes using abbreviated descriptions with no clear categorization, while the full legal definitions live in the Illinois statutes and are written in dense language. Existing federal classification systems also fit Illinois offenses poorly, making it difficult to group related offenses and analyze broader crime patterns. This project linked offense codes to statute text, generated plain-language summaries, and developed an interpretable taxonomy for Illinois criminal statutes.

The team used Large Language Model (LLMs) to write concise summaries of each offense, guided by legal-writing rules and expert-reviewed examples to preserve legal meaning while keeping the text structured enough for semantic categorization. Broad categories were derived from emerging semantic themes across offense entries in the OCT, and each offense was assigned to one. Within categories, offenses with similar summaries were grouped into finer subcategories, which the LLM labeled in clear legal terms. The pipeline was also designed to support frictionless regeneration of the summaries and taxonomy as the OCT is updated semi-annually.

Figure 1 traces “Aggravated Violent and Threat Offenses” through subcategories down to specific clusters such as “Sexual Assault against Minors.” This taxonomy lets practitioners and researchers explore offenses at multiple levels, check classification consistency, and track charging patterns.

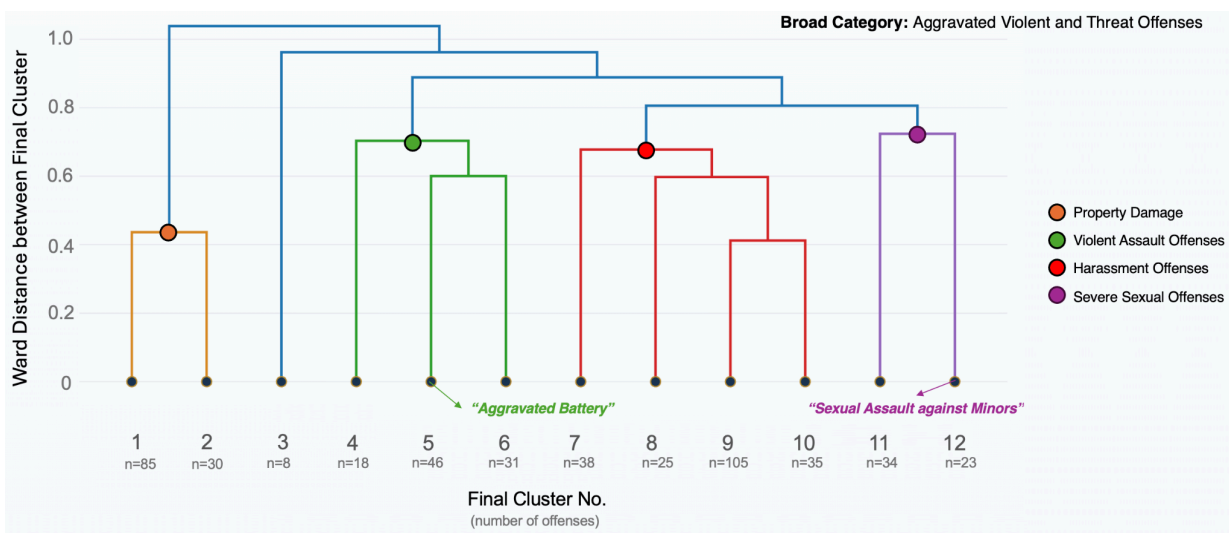


Figure 1. Example taxonomy for the “Aggravated Violent and Threat Offenses” broad category.